LECTURE 4: FEEDBACK SKILLS IN COMMUNICATION

Introduction

In the first lecture, Communication has been defined as the exchange of ideas, thoughts and feelings, that result in an understanding response. What this means is that communication is a two-way process that requires a message to be sent from one party and requires the other party to respond or act in an appropriate way, based on the communication. The response given by the receiver as a result of the communication determines whether the communication process was successful or not, and this response is termed as "feedback".

Since communication is a two-way process, it goes without saying that feedback becomes an integral part of the communication process. No communication is complete without feedback.

Feedback completes the process of communication and ensures that there has been no miscommunication. If appropriate feedback is not given or if the feedback clearly indicates that the message has not been understood, then the process of communication has failed. In this scenario, the entire process of communication will have to be repeated, eliminating all barriers, to ensure effective communication.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this lecture you should be able to:

- Define feedback
- State the importance of feedback in communication
- Give the characteristics of constructive feedback
- Use guidelines to give constructive feedback

What is feedback?

Feedback is the response or reaction of the receiver after perceiving or understanding the message.
It enables the sender to evaluate the effectiveness of the message. It is inevitably essential in case of two-way communication.

Without feedback, ***two way communication*** is either ineffective or incomplete. Feedback is the only way to gain receiver's response and depending on the feedback, sender can tack further steps.



Figure: Feedback in Business Communication

In order to reduce the impact of your own assumptions and attitudes, it is important to provide the speaker with feedback. It is a way of demonstrating that you are listening and checking that you have understood what you have heard.

Forms of feedback

Feedback can be provided by the receiver in a number of ways:

- **Verbal Feedback –** Verbal feedback in the form of phrases like "yes" or "I understand what you are saying" show that the message has been transmitted clearly and the process of communication is complete.
- **Non-verbal Feedback –** Feedback can also be non-verbal. Just a nod or an expression on the face of the receiver is sometimes enough to indicate whether the communication has been successful or not.
- **Action –** Another way of giving feedback is taking action in accordance with the message sent by the sender. Once the appropriate action is taken based on the message, it automatically indicates that the process of communication was successful.

Positive and negative feedback

Feedback may be **positive or negative**.

Positive feedback is the kind of feedback which is more or less acceptable or satisfactory to the sender. It means that the recipient of the message has responded

in the way intended by the sender and taken the intended course of action. It signifies that everything is on the right track and no corrective measure regarding communication is necessary.

On the other hand, if the recipient does not understand what the sender wants to convey, the feedback must be poor and further communication becomes necessary to wipe out the misunderstanding.

Negative feedback suggests that the communication has not been effective and some correction, adjustment or re-assessment is required in the process.

IMPORTANCE OF FEEDBACK IN HUMAN COMMUNICATION

So why is feedback important?

Feedback is very essential thing in human communication because of the following:

(i)Feedback ensures that the message sent to receiver has successfully reached. We get to verify this fact once the receiver of message responds to message sent to him earlier by a sender.

(ii)Feedback completes whole process of human communication. Therefore, it is the backbone in human communication and also communication will not be effective without getting feedback.

(iii)Feedback is useful for making better decisions. Example, one person can decide to give invitation card to other person if the first person who was given such card is busy with other important activities.

(iv)Feedback helps us to know emotions and feelings of a receiver. It therefore shows a mood of a receiver. Good examples of feelings may be sadness, annoyance, happiness, angriness and pity.

Note: Communication becomes more effective if it becomes "two ways traffic". This means that communication must involve a person who sends and receives a message simultaneously. In other words, communication is an interactive process while one person is talking and the other is listening

Characteristics of effective feedback

1. **Intention**: Effective feedback is directed towards improving work performance and making the worker a more valuable asset. It is not a personal attack. Feedback is directed towards aspect of the job.
2. **Specificity:** Be specific rather than saying things like "you always" or "you never". Vague criticism causes resentment.
3. **Description:** Effective feedback can also be characterized as descriptive rather than evaluative. It tells the receivers what he or she has done in objective terms, rather than presenting a value judgment.
4. **Usefulness:** Effective feedback is information that the receiver can use to improve performance. If it is not something the receiver can correct, it is not worth mentioning.
5. **Timeliness:** There are considerations in timing feedback properly. As a rule, the more immediate the feedback, the better. This way the receiver has a better chance of knowing what the sender is talking about and can take corrective action.
6. Clarity: Effective feedback must be clearly understood by the recipient. A good way of checking this is to ask the recipient to restate the major points of discussion.
7. Validity: In order, for feedback, to be effective, it must be reliable and valid.
8. Readiness: In order, for feedback, to be effective, the receiver must be ready to receive. When feedback is imposed upon the receiver it is much less effective.

Feedback should be a continuous process as the audience and communicators are neither always the same persons, nor they are interacting in the same situation. The extension agent shall take steps to analyze the responses of the audience, which may be positive, negative or no response. If there has been no response or negative response to a message, the extension agent shall find out reasons for the same. If it pertains to research, the problem should be referred as feedback information to research, to find out solutions for the same.

Guidelines for giving constructive /Effective feedback

In giving feedback it is important to use the following **techniques**

1. **Consider the needs of others**. Feedback should be meant to help another grow personally and /or professionally

   Consider the following examples of feedback:

   Destructive: "That is a dumb idea. How am I supposed to pitch that to the boss?"

   Constructive: "I feel uncomfortable with that proposal. My hope would be to include the latest statistics and show how it ties to our staffing patterns."

2. **Describe the Behaviour or Content**. People are less likely to become defensive if feedback is free of blame or interpretation of the motive. Separate the 'deed' from the 'doer' –reject the behavior while keeping intact the intrinsic value of the person. Eg consider the following examples:

   Interpreting: "I suspect your anger comes from your lack of experience, would you agree?"

   Labeling: "That's a very immature response. You'll see the issue more clearly when you are my age."

   Constructive: "I notice that people shut-down or get emotional when you raise your voice and start blaming others."
3. **Focus on behavior that can be changed or is pertinent to the concerns of the group.** Do not focus on personal style, habits, or personal characteristics. Examples:

   Ineffective: "Your grasp of English is limited and I find I am having trouble paying attention to you."

   Effective: "Could you please speak up a little and more slowly? I am having trouble hearing your comments from where you are seated."
4. **Be specific**. To provide insight, the recipient must clearly understand what behaviour is under discussion. Look at the examples below:

   Generalized: "I liked your input tonight."

   Specific: "Your recommendations on social media were complete, well thought out and valuable to our deliberations."
5. **Ask permission to give feedback**. Ask for their agreement before you share the feedback. Eg

   "I'd like a chance to respond to that. May I tell you how that comment made me feel?"

   " Your presentation has really angered me. May I tell you why?"
6. **Give feedback as soon as possible after ineffective behaviour is displayed**. When we 'store' feedback, it can become overwhelming resulting in ineffective communication thereby creating major communication barriers.

   Behaviors cannot change if feedback is withheld or comes months after the fact.

- ***Summary : Learning Points***
- While giving negative or critical feedback can be difficult, it is nevertheless vital that such feedback is given honestly, in order to allow other people to know where they are and what steps they can take to improve their work.

- People are likely to become defensive when they feel threatened or attacked, and will be more concerned with constructing a defence rather than on listening to you.
- When a person feels put-down or insignificant because of the communication with you, they are likely to invest in attempts to re-establish self-worth; and will be more concerned with portraying self importance rather than listening to you.
- There are a number of guidelines toward giving feedback effectively, e.g. being specific, offering a solution, checking it is understood, being descriptive, supportive, validating, open to receiving feedback and focussing on the problem rather than 'attacking' the person, etc.
- Steps for giving more formal feedback include agreeing when & where the meeting should occur and what will be discussed; beginning by asking open questions; emphasizing the constructive purpose of the feedback; being open to receiving both positive and critical feedback from the student; and developing a plan for improvement.
- It is important to monitor, evaluate and continue to develop feedback effectiveness.

Unit 2: EFFECTIVE QUESTIONING SKILLS

Introduction

Questioning and listening skills are pivotal to effective communication and creating mutual understanding. These vital communication tools are requisite for building effective working and personal relationships. Interpersonal communication skills are the foundation of business success and the most highly sought after employees are those who are able to capitalise on these abilities.

In this lecture we focus on Effective questioning. This is another valuable tool which will enable you to find and analyse the information that others hold. Knowing how to accurately and effectively ask various types of questions, and under which contexts, will minimise the effort and maximise the results in your interpersonal interactions. This course will also teach you techniques to enhance your understanding of the information you receive to ensure clarity and prevent ambiguity.

Learning outcomes

By the end of this lecture you should be able to

- Discover the vital role questions play in our everyday communication and how they can be used to strategically gather information
- Understand how your questioning stance and intention impacts the way in which you ask for information and receive answers
- Identify specific questioning techniques and find out how they are best suited to specific occasions, people and information
- Comprehend the pool of question types that can be used to obtain the required information with the appropriate level of detail

The role of questions in communication

Developing your ability to ask questions that draw out the information needed to aid your understanding of the speaker's situation and help them find a resolution is crucial to your success.

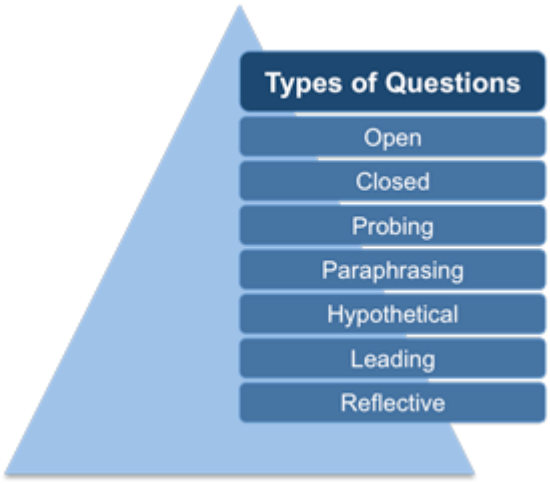
Your questions help you to:

- Focus attention
- Elicit new ideas
- Encourage exploration
- Foster commitment



Types of questions

There are seven different types of questions you can ask, and you should make sure that you have a clear idea of why you are asking a question in a particular way and at a particular time.



Let us now look at each of these question types in details.

Open questions are commonly used to encourage the other party to open up, so that you can gather the necessary information. They often start with why, what, where, which, and how.

You will find that they work best when the conversation is already flowing freely. For example:

'*How was that strategy useful?*'
'*What did you do to keep your team on track?*'
'*How would you respond to this customer's concerns?*'

Probing questions can be used to clarify something that has already been said or to find out more detail about it. Many of them are helpful in creating rapport, but you must take care not over-use them as this can make people feel as if they are being interrogated or even attacked.
Make sure your verbal and nonverbal signs are neutral or supportive when asking such questions. This type of question is useful in uncovering details that may have initially been overlooked or thought irrelevant. For example:

Why do you think this is the case?'
'*What does that mean?*'
'*What are your options for solving the problem?*'
'*Could you be more specific?*'
'*Who is involved? Who are the key stakeholders?*'
'*What needs addressing?*
'*Is there an option that you have not yet considered?*'
'*How have you managed to put up with the situation to date?*'
'*How would an objective observer describe this situation?*'
'*What do you care most about in this situation?*'
'*What are your concerns?*'

Closed questions- these are questions that require a 'yes' or 'no' answer. Such questions should be used sparingly because they tend to make any conversation feel awkward and one-sided, but in some instances an affirmative or negative answer is all that is needed. In sensitive situations, they are best avoided as they can harm the rapport and empathy that are an essential part of active listening.

Reflective questions- are questions frequently used to check and clarify your understanding. This style of question reflects back to the speaker what they have just said and allows them to fully explore their knowledge of a situation.
These questions also provide an opportunity for the other person to give voice to the emotions they felt at that particular time without you having to interpret why this happened in your question. Use of reflective questions dispenses with you having to express an interpretation or judge why the other person felt this way.
For example:
Speaker - 'I feel frustrated with myself.'
Listener - 'And what is this "frustrated with myself" experience like?'

Speaker - 'Those people in dispatch are always messing me about.'
Listener - 'What does that "messing you about" behavior involve?'

Leading questions - are useful in situations where you require a desired answer or need to influence people's thinking. For example:
'So wouldn't it have been better to…?'
'Don't you think we should have…?'

Hypothetical questions- these are questions that allow you to gauge how someone might act or what they think about a possible situation. They are effective in getting the person to think up and discuss new ideas or approaches to a problem. For example:
'What would you do if…?'
'What would happen if…?'

Paraphrasing questions are one of the best ways you can check your own understanding of what the speaker has said. For example:
Speaker - 'I can't deliver on that unless accounts get the information to me the same day.'
Listener - 'I'm hearing you say that you could deliver, if the accounts department were able to get the information to you on the same day you requested it. Am I understanding this correctly?'

Whenever you ask a question think about how and where you are trying to 'take' the speaker. If the question you ask does not result in a positive step forward then you must ask yourself three simple questions: 'Did I ask it in the wrong way?', 'Could the words I used be misinterpreted?' and 'Was the type of question appropriate?' The answers you get by asking yourself these things will enable you to develop your questioning competency and alter your behaviour in the future.

Key Points

- Questions can help you to focus attention, elicit new ideas, encourage exploration, and foster commitment.
- There are seven different types of question you can use: open, probing, closed, reflective, leading, hypothetical, and paraphrasing.